Edelin bravely sought to quash it before it spread. He repeated the claims of the medieval *Canon Episcopi* that witchcraft was an illusion and that witches couldn't really fly at night to meet Satan and make a pact with him. Edelin was then himself accused of being a witch and arrested. Under torture he confessed that he personally had flown on a broomstick and signed a pact with the Devil and that it was Satan who commissioned him to preach that witchcraft was an illusion. His judges were lenient with him; he was spared execution and got life imprisonment instead.[83]

The witch hunts illustrate the dark side of creating an information sphere. As with rabbinical discussions of the Talmud and scholastic discussions of Christian scriptures, the witch hunts were fuelled by an expanding ocean of information that instead of representing reality created a new reality. Witches were not an objective reality. Nobody in early modern Europe had sex with Satan or was capable of flying on broomsticks and creating hailstorms. But witches became an intersubjective reality. Like money, witches were made real by exchanging information about witches.

An entire witch-hunting bureaucracy dedicated itself to such exchanges. Theologians, lawyers, inquisitors and the owners of printing presses made a living by collecting and producing information about witches, cataloguing different species of witches, investigating how witches behaved and recommending how they could be exposed and defeated. Professional witch-hunters offered their services to governments and municipalities, charging large sums of money. Archives were filled by detailed reports of witch-hunting expeditions, protocols of witch trials and lengthy confessions extracted from the alleged witches.

Expert witch-hunters used all that data to refine their theories further. Like scholars arguing about the correct interpretation of scripture, the witch-hunters debated the correct interpretation of *The Hammer of the Witches* and other influential books. The witch-hunting bureaucracy did what bureaucracy often does: it invented the intersubjective category of 'witches' and imposed it on reality. It even printed forms, with standard accusations and confessions of witches and blank spaces left for dates, names and the signature of the accused. All that information produced a lot of order and power; it was a means for certain people to gain authority and for society as a whole to discipline its members. But it produced zero truth and zero wisdom.